

Physical Spaces

We recommend beginning with simplifying your physical space because it's the most tangible category, and it can have a profound impact on the rest of your life. And since our minds are the beginning place for our actions, we're going to emphasize some of the reasons simplification is a good idea.

Less clutter = less stress. When there's stuff all over my (Jill's) home, my senses are heightened (whether or not I'm fully aware of it). The stuff demands my attention, whether or not I have the time to give it. From "clean me" to "fix me" to "organize me" to "use me," the stuff calls out. And sometimes I respond, "Not right now," or "Okay, right now, even though I've got five other more important things to do," or "Gotta put that on the list," or "one-click buy that replacement." And all these little conversations with my things turn into less room for conversation with my people. I am more likely to disproportionately react to stressors and experience tension inside myself and irritation with others. Alternatively, when there are fewer or simpler things to maintain and use, I feel calmer, I'm not as distracted, and my energy isn't depleted by all the physical clutter.

Less time and energy spent cleaning and organizing. When I was younger, I loved collecting things. Candle snuffers, tiny boxes, and snow babies (if you don't know what these are, it's worth the internet search so you can laugh along imagining eight-year-old Jill fawning over these creepy ceramic figurines). I would often show my Gimba (what I call my grandma) my new trinkets.

She would say, "Do you know what I call that? Dust collectors!" At the time, I thought it was such a buzzkill, but as I get older, I hear her words more and more in my own voice. I don't want stuff because I don't want to clean it! And because those dang Beanie Babies, Pogs, and rock collection never actually held their value despite all the promises.

When you simplify your physical space, you also have the opportunity to redefine your meaning of "enough." This is different for every person, but without it you will flounder to know where your satisfaction lies. As you work to find, make room for, spend, and live out of your values, you will be closer to a life of contentment and, by proxy, one of simplicity.

Knowing what's enough is a process, and your definition will continuously be refined throughout your life, but when this is your aim, you